A cylindrical chess set

To end his series on chess sets, **Mike Darlow** turns a set based on cylinders

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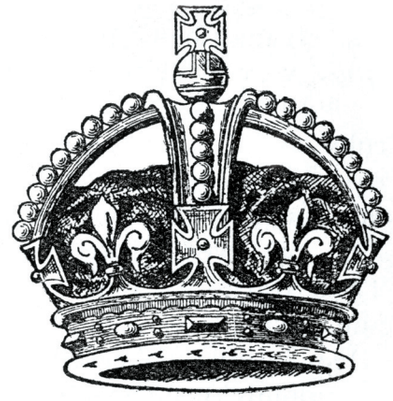
In this last of the five chess set articles I'll show a set design based on the cylinder – for a skilled woodturner the very antithesis of craftsmanship. However, as this article illustrates the challenge of the cylindrical constraint can be overcome to yield a set design that is elegant, fresh and has high playability.

Design features

- The piece heights conform to the typical norms because they are piece signatures.
- In the Staunton set the top of the king represents an arched crown, the queen's a crown with points, but without arches. These two crown types are represented by the convex and concave tops to the king K1 and queen Q1 respectively. These two mating tops could also represent a sexual connectedness.
- The bishop B1 has a vertical slot or channel that represents the gap between the front and back parts of a mitre.
- In most western sets, including the Staunton, the knight piece signature is the head of a charger. Unfortunately a large proportion of charger heads aren't convincingly carved and thus detract from the aesthetic success of the sets which include them. The diagram on the following page and the photo below show a range of turned knight pieces.

1) The drilled hole in knight N1, a feature introduced by Jorn Pfab, results in a piece signature which represents a charger's head and neck. Or does it represent the vision slot in a helm? By turning a knight N2 on two parallel axes, a more convincing



An arched crown

A pointed crown without arches

Illustrations scanned from A.C. Fox-Davies, Complete Guide to Heraldry, London, T.C. & E.C. Jack, 1909

Six different knight designs

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